

## Leading LIGHTS

**MTV** Having reinvented itself, MTV is now one of the biggest platforms for the McIndian youth to be recognised. Their programme, *Roadies*, in 2003 spawned talent hunt shows, right from VJ to model hunts.



**RAHUL GANDHI** Effectively responsible for ushering in a younger era in Indian politics. It was only in 2004 that he came into active politics, but

his entry was a given, unlike his father Rajiv Gandhi.



**SANDEEP UNNIKRIISHNAN** He emerged as one of the greatest heroes of 26/11 and was associated with the Mumbai attacks in the same way that Vikram Batra was associated with the Kargil War in 1999. His name was added to the long list of heroes who gave up their lives fighting militancy.



**ABHINAV BINDRA** The current world and Olympic champion became a national obsession after he won the country's first individual Olympics gold. His performance at the Beijing Olympics put the spotlight on shooting and earned him a place in the

Queen's Baton Relay for the Commonwealth Games 2010.



## SPIN-OFFS

### Rock and Roll

#### Net Workers

Social networking sites, the lifeblood of the youth, are used extensively not only for flirting and finding friends but also to connect for social and philanthropic purposes.

#### Demographic Dividend

In 2020, the average Indian will be only 29 years old. This large, young working group will drive growth and savings. But the country will have to address problems in education and training.



#### Yeah Dude

With call centre lines stretching to the West, the young have not only acquired accents but attitudes too.

#### Youth Markets

Hooked to consumer culture, youngsters are the favoured target group for advertisers, from Pepsi's Youngistan in 2008 to Allen Solly's 'I hate ugly' campaign in 2009.

all working hard at gaining experience in their respective disciplines. One day they, too, will find their places in their own ecosystems and start training their successors. The players change, but the roles don't. Why have we been talking about Youth Power so much? It's not like the young people of today will stay young forever, except Dev Anand. Perhaps because the stage is changing too, and very rapidly. And there are new roles available that only the ridiculously young can play.

Today's young people are so much more aware of the world than I was at their age. I speak of the young in my own tiny substratum of the Indian population, the only one I can claim to even begin to understand—children who grew up after this globalisation and liberalisation brouhaha. They no longer have to go through the education grind with the sole objective of escaping this country, travelling westwards and spending their adult lives discovering that life is disappointing everywhere. Today's young people are happy to be here, and to actually get involved. Yes, they have access previous generations didn't—broadband, huge book stores and innumerable news channels—but it's not just that. They actually feel connected, feel a sense of entitlement I never had as a child. They've been brought up on a never-ending diet of hype, of success stories, without that overwhelming sense of cultural inferiority that burdened us. For them, apathy actually takes a degree of sustained effort—there's simply too much going on. They have complicated love lives, exotic hobbies, finely customised social profiles, definite opinions and a confidence, a sense of having the right to enjoy

I AM OLD. I AM 39. IF YOU SEE the population of the country, 60 per cent of our population is below 40.

RAHUL GANDHI  
CONGRESS MP

their own lives that's very impressive. Very Youth Power.

On the other hand, I know so many people younger than I am who have already turned into their parents, or worse. And people in their 40s and 50s who, instead of being civilised and sitting around complaining or waiting for heart attacks, are growing younger. Most of my older friends are toned, enthusiastic, adventurous and disgustingly alive. And if you look around you, see our country changing every day, you'll find that the people doing the maddest things, executing the wildest schemes, living the fullest lives, are not necessarily part of this dream demographic, this marketing-department Holy Grail generation. We've got Youth Power in spades, but I really don't think it's got anything to do with biological age. Will all of this, this mixture of ambition and idealism and rejuvenation make India a better place to live in for everyone in it? I'm far too powerless to know, and certainly not old enough to judge.

Samit Basu has just completed his fourth novel and is planning his next.

